ADU Contractor Quote Checklist

Put every bid on the same ledger before you sign. 20 questions across the six phases of an ADU build.

THE 4-BUCKET RULE

Every line in a quote must fall into exactly one bucket. If a line fits none — ask where it went.

INCLUDED	ALLOWANCE	EXCLUDED	OWNER-PAID
In the contractor's price. No extra cost to you.	Budgeted amount only — you pay the difference if it costs more.	Not in scope. You hire someone else or pay extra.	You pay the vendor directly (permits, appliances, etc.).

20 QUESTIONS TO ASK EVERY BIDDER

PHASE 1 — SITE WORK & FOUN

- [ ] 1. Grading, excavation, and haul-away: included or allowance?
- [ ] 2. Foundation type specified (slab / raised / pier)? Soil report required?
- [ ] 3. Demolition of existing structure (garage conversion): included?
- [ ] 4. Tree removal, fencing, or retaining walls: included or excluded?

PHASE 2 — FRAMING & SHELL

- [ ] 5. Lumber / framing package: fixed price or subject to market adjustment?
- [ ] 6. Roofing material and warranty length specified in writing?
- [ ] 7. Windows and exterior doors: brand and model listed?
- [ ] 8. Siding / stucco and exterior paint: included?

PHASE 3 — ROUGH-INS (MEP)

- [ ] 9. Plumbing rough-in: sewer lateral tie-in point defined?
- [ ] 10. Electrical: is a panel upgrade needed — and who pays for it?
- [ ] 11. HVAC: mini-split vs. central — unit size and brand specified?
- [ ] 12. Insulation: type and R-value listed for walls, ceiling, floor?

PHASE 4 — FINISHES

- [ ] 13. Flooring, tile, countertops: allowance dollar amounts stated per item?
- [ ] 14. Cabinets: stock, semi-custom, or custom — which one?
- [ ] 15. Plumbing and light fixtures: allowance, or owner-supplied?
- [ ] 16. Interior paint: number of coats and which rooms?

PHASE 5 — SOFT COSTS

- [ ] 17. Permit, plan-check, school, and impact fees: contractor-paid or owner-paid?
- [ ] 18. Design, structural engineering, Title 24 calculations: included?

PHASE 6 — UTILITY HOOKUPS

- [ ] 19. Utility hookup / meter fees: included, excluded, or owner-paid? (CA waits run 9–12 months — SB 1196)
- [ ] 20. Final inspections and certificate of occupancy: whose responsibility? Warranty terms in writing?

WALK-AWAY RED FLAGS

- ✕ Single lump-sum price with no line items
- ✕ "Allowances" with no dollar amounts attached
- ✕ No mention of permits, fees, or utility hookups
- ✕ Verbal promises that are not in the written contract
- ✕ Deposit over 10% or $1,000 (CA legal limit for home-improvement contracts)

Compare your quotes against published California builds → everylineitem.com/compare

Want the full 6-phase ledger as a spreadsheet? Get the $39 ADU Cost Workbook at everylineitem.com

Educational reference only. Verify fees and requirements with your city or county before making decisions.